KISHŌTENKETSU IN VIDEO GAME DESIGN

Intro

Hey there, fellow game devs! It's time for a storytelling journey like no other. You see, I recently stumbled upon an ancient narrative gem called Kishōtenketsu, and let me tell you – it has changed the way I approach crafting stories and designing games. Gone are the days of run-of-the-mill three-act structures; Kishōtenketsu brings new dimensions to how we captivate our audiences.

From its Eastern origins, this four-phase treasure includes Ki (Introduction), Shō (Development), Ten (Twist), and Ketsu (Resolution). The beauty lies in how each phase seamlessly connects, creating unforgettable experiences that keep readers and players hooked from beginning to end.

Let's delve into the world of Kishōtenketsu together as I guide you through each phase, sharing invaluable tips to help elevate your own creative endeavors. Trust me – once you've embraced the power of Kishōtenketsu, there's no turning back! So, buckle up and prepare for a wild ride in storytelling mastery.

What is Kishōtenketsu?

The enchanting narrative structure of Kishōtenketsu traces its roots back to classical Chinese, Korean, and Japanese literature, where it flourished as a unique way to create captivating stories without relying on conflict as a central driving force. This four-phase framework – Ki, Shō, Ten, and Ketsu – has since transcended its origins and ventured into the realm of video game design. A prime example is how this engaging structure has been implemented in creating levels for the iconic Mario games by Shigeru Miyamoto and Koichi Hayashida. By introducing new elements or challenges in each stage, while subtly foreshadowing what lies ahead, the developers weave together an experience that mirrors Kishōtenketsu's artful progression. As players embark on their journey with Mario, they encounter increasingly complex platform designs and inventive gameplay twists, culminating in memorable boss battles and rewarding resolutions — all guided by the timeless principles of Kishōtenketsu storytelling.

What sets Kishōtenketsu apart is its freedom from transformational narratives. Our protagonist doesn't need to endure hardships and emerge changed for better or worse. Yes, there's a twist, but it doesn't have to be groundbreaking or even negative. Twists can simply offer humor or delight the reader with an unexpected surprise.

Let's look at a short example of how a story works with Kishōtenketsu.

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In an age-old mountain realm (Ki), a group of dwarves
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stumbled upon a sealed cavern while mining for precious gems (Shō). To their astonishment, breaking the seal unleashed a gentle, luminous creature with healing powers (Ten). The dwarves and the mystical being formed an unbreakable bond, revitalizing their community through newfound wisdom and prosperity (Ketsu).